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2026 SWITCH GLOBAL COMPETITION

OFFICIAL CASE PACKET.

Where the next generation of energy leaders take on
the world's most pressing challenge.

SEP 14

COMPETITION BEGINS

DEC 5

LIVE FINALS

\$50K

PRIZE POOL

420

TEAMS · 58 COUNTRIES

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01 // WELCOME

WELCOME TO THE 2026 COMPETITION

Switch Energy Alliance welcomes you to the SEVENTH annual Switch Global Competition, the largest event of its kind. Students from every corner of the globe will collaborate to take on one of the greatest challenges of our time: finding real, workable solutions to energy poverty.

The 2026 competition is our most ambitious yet, and it has been redesigned from the ground up. Instead of a single deadline only weeks away, you will move through four progressive rounds, each with a clear deliverable, a defined evaluation method, and a decision point. Each round is paired with a session of the Integrated Learning Series that teaches exactly the skills your next deliverable demands. You will not just compete; you will learn how energy analysis, planning, budgeting, and storytelling are actually done, at the moment you need each skill most.

The journey to the live finals on December 5 will not be easy, and that is the point. Teams that advance will have been tested on written analysis, plan design, budget discipline, video presentation, and live defense in front of a panel of energy industry leaders. This packet is your single source of truth for the entire competition: read it closely, keep it nearby, and check the [2026 Switch Competition Hub](#) on [The Grid](#) for announcements and updates throughout.

We are looking forward to the innovative solutions your team conceives. Good luck!

The Switch Competition Team

Switch Energy Alliance | Austin, Texas

HOW TO USE THIS PACKET

Everything you need is in these pages: the prompt, the five countries, the round structure, every rubric, every deadline, and a step-by-step guide to The Grid. If you read only three sections tonight, read The 2026 Prompt (Section 4), The Four Rounds (Section 7), and Your Guide to The Grid (Section 12). Then come back for the rest before you start your Round 1 brief.

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02 // WHO WE ARE

SWITCH ENERGY ALLIANCE & SWITCH CAMPUS

Switch Energy Alliance (SEA) is an Austin, Texas-based 501(c)(3) nonprofit dedicated to advancing understanding of energy systems and accelerating solutions to global energy poverty. Since its founding in 2016, SEA has built on the remarkable popularity of the global energy film Switch, screened in over 50 countries and thousands of universities and viewed by more than 15 million people, and the more recent film Switch On, which showcases the realities of energy poverty in several developing countries. SEA has created hundreds of free video lectures, developed Switch Classroom, a free online energy platform used in thousands of classes around the world, and launched Energy Switch, an energy and climate television series streaming on PBS.org.

Switch Campus is SEA's higher education program, and the Switch Global Competition is its flagship initiative. The competition shares SEA's mission: to engage students in holding informed conversations, inspire competitors to broaden their perspective about the global energy situation, and develop actionable plans aimed at creating a brighter future for everyone.

OUR POSITION ON ENERGY

All forms of energy matter in achieving the goal of ending energy poverty. Fossil fuels, renewables, nuclear, and emerging technologies all belong in your analysis. The competition rewards plans that fit a country's real resources, constraints, and people, not plans that fit an ideology.

THE COMPETITION COMMUNITY

In 2025, the competition drew 295 registered teams from 27 countries, supported by more than 170 volunteer mentors and judges from across the energy industry and academia. In 2026 the field is a record 420 teams: nearly 1,500 students from 339 institutions in 58 countries, 20 of them competing for the first time, spanning engineering, business, policy, environmental science, economics, communications, and adjacent disciplines. Cross-functional teams mirror the realities of the energy industry, and the strongest teams use that diversity deliberately.

03 // THE CHALLENGE

WHAT IS ENERGY POVERTY?

In 2010, the World Economic Forum defined energy poverty as the lack of access to sustainable, modern energy services and products. It is not only a matter of sustainability: energy poverty can be found in all situations where there is a lack of adequate, affordable, reliable, quality, safe, and environmentally sound energy supply to support

development. Although energy is the engine of civilization, access to adequate and affordable sources of energy is not equally distributed on the planet.

Energy poverty is firmly and constantly intertwined with economic and social development. Countries with fewer overall resources often depend on unreliable energy services, which contribute to malnourishment, unhealthy living conditions, and limited access to education and employment. But even developed and developing countries face internal issues of energy poverty, especially when comparing urban and rural populations. Significant portions of their populations do not have affordable and reliable access to energy, hindering societal development and economic growth.

To improve access to safe and reliable energy, governments must maintain and expand their energy networks by funding capital projects. Leaders are aware of the challenges and already allocate a portion of government spending toward energy development, but these limited budgets are often insufficient to cover maintenance and new construction. The World Health Organization estimates that approximately 2.4 billion people live in some form of energy poverty today. Addressing it benefits not only those in poverty but the entire world, expanding international commercial markets and alleviating geopolitical tensions. The first step is global awareness and education, and that is where you come in.

COMPETITION GOALS & OBJECTIVES

The goals and objectives of this competition are for participants to:

1. Understand the widespread nature, challenges, contributing factors, and diversity of energy poverty, its impact on people's daily lives, and the broader energy justice issues brought on by energy poverty globally.
2. Consider how, if possible, resources or best practices from one country might be traded or shared with a neighboring country.
3. Consider the social, economic, and environmental impact of government energy policies on a country's development.
4. Consider all forms of energy as potential solutions, including fossil fuels, renewables, nuclear, and technologies that may currently be in developmental stages.

04 // YOUR ASSIGNMENT

THE 2026 PROMPT

This year we are offering one country from each of five regions: the Americas, Africa, Europe, MENA (Middle East/North Africa), and Asia-Pacific. These countries represent very different faces of energy poverty, from massive access deficits to dependency traps to systems that look strong on paper but fail the people at their edges. Your team will choose one country and carry it through all four rounds of the competition.

REGION	COUNTRY	THE STORY IN ONE LINE
MENA (Middle East/North Africa)	Tunisia	Abundant sunshine, yet spending a record share of GDP importing fossil fuels.
Europe	Moldova	27 GW of renewable potential idle while a dependency trap leaves homes cold.
Asia-Pacific	Uzbekistan	World-class gas reserves in terminal production decline, exporting while importing.
Africa	Nigeria	A major energy producer where 87 million people still live without electricity.
Americas	Peru	Near-universal access on paper, single-corridor fragility and last-mile gaps in reality.

YOUR TASKS

Across the four rounds, your team will:

1. **Choose one of the five countries** for analysis, and commit to it in your Round 1 submission.
2. **Conduct a thorough energy analysis** of the energy landscape in your chosen country, structured around the 8 energy poverty factors (Section 6).
3. **Propose a 10-year plan** that will help your country achieve long-term goals in relieving energy poverty, including a budget within the country's maximum allowable spend.
4. **Design a cross-border barter arrangement** with one to three neighboring countries, exchanging energy or resources to mutual benefit.
5. **Present and defend your plan**, first in a semifinal video presentation and then, for the top five teams, live before a panel of energy industry leaders.

YOUR ROLE

Tailor your work as if your team were an advisory council assigned to propose energy poverty relief projects to the Ministry of Energy of your selected country. Every round builds on the last: the analysis feeds the plan, the plan feeds the presentation, and the presentation is defended live.

A CORE ELEMENT: BARTERING

The competition asks every team to design a barter arrangement: the exchange of goods or services without the use of money. Your 10-year strategic plan must include an energy-for-energy or energy-for-resources barter system with one or more neighboring countries. This is a creative, real-world avenue to design mutually beneficial trade strategies and to explore how regional cooperation can effectively and sustainably bridge energy gaps.

Assess your chosen country's existing energy resources, consumption patterns, infrastructure status, growth potential, and industrial energy needs, then identify at least one regional neighbor for a practical barter partnership. Your proposal must deliver a well-reasoned analysis for selecting the specific neighboring country or countries, citing significant economic, technical, and geopolitical advantages. All analytical content must be properly cited using credible, up-to-date sources.

RULES FOR BARTERING

- **Eligible partners.** The country or countries selected for bartering must be chosen from the eligible partners listed in that country's overview in Section 5. Eligible partners are the chosen country's neighbors: countries sharing a land border, or a direct maritime boundary where that is the natural trade route (Italy, for Tunisia, across the Strait of Sicily). No other countries may be used.
- **Number of partners.** Teams may propose bartering agreements with a minimum of one and a maximum of three neighboring countries.
- **Nature of the barter.** Agreements can involve energy-for-energy exchanges (preferred) or energy-for-resources exchanges, such as trading energy for infrastructure materials, necessary minerals, technology, or manpower.
- **Objective.** The barter structure should be mutually beneficial to all countries involved, should help maximize energy access and alleviate energy poverty in your chosen country and its partners, and should contribute to long-term energy sustainability, political and economic stability, and regional cooperation.

05 // THE FIVE COUNTRIES

COUNTRY OVERVIEWS

The overviews below orient you to each country's geography, economy, and energy story. They are a starting point, not a substitute for research: the depth, currency, and specificity of your own analysis is precisely what Rounds 1 and 2 evaluate. Budget parameters for every country appear in the Financial Information table in Section 6.

MENA (MIDDLE EAST/NORTH AFRICA)

TUNISIA

Tunisia is a North African country on the Mediterranean coast, bordered by Algeria to the west and Libya to the east and southeast. It is home to roughly 12.3 million people, with its capital and largest city at Tunis. Classified by the World Bank as a lower-middle-income country, Tunisia has a diversified economy built on services and tourism, light manufacturing and textiles, phosphate mining, and agriculture, most famously olive oil. Poverty is concentrated in the rural interior: coastal regions are markedly wealthier than the center-west agricultural heartland, and that regional divide runs through the country's energy story as well.

Tunisia's energy paradox is a transition that never happened. The country once produced enough oil and gas to be largely energy self-sufficient, but domestic production has declined for decades while renewable alternatives went unbuilt. Today roughly 95% of electricity generation runs on natural gas, the majority of it imported from Algeria, and the country's energy independence rate has been falling as production shrinks and demand grows. The energy trade deficit has reached record levels approaching 7% of GDP. Meanwhile, Tunisia holds some of

the best solar and wind resources in the Mediterranean, with technically deployable solar potential measured in the hundreds of gigawatts, yet renewables supply only a small fraction of electricity against an official 35% target for 2030. A country with abundant sunshine is spending a substantial share of its entire economic output importing fossil fuels. Grid access itself is near-universal; the energy poverty challenge lives in affordability, supply quality, import exposure, and the widening gap between renewable ambition and delivery.

KEY INDUSTRIES SHAPED BY ENERGY POVERTY

- **Tourism and services.** The largest sector of the economy depends on reliable, affordable power for hospitality, transport, and coastal infrastructure, and is directly exposed to electricity cost increases driven by imported gas.
- **Manufacturing and textiles.** Export-oriented light manufacturing competes on cost; energy price volatility and supply quality directly affect competitiveness in European markets.
- **Agriculture and phosphate mining.** Irrigation, processing, and mining operations in the interior face both higher energy burdens and weaker infrastructure than the coast.

BARTERING NOTE

Eligible barter countries: Algeria, Libya, and Italy. Algeria and Libya share direct borders with Tunisia; Italy is the one non-border exception in the 2026 competition, included for the existing Tunisia-Italy energy infrastructure relationship. Teams should research each eligible country's energy resources, needs, and constraints when selecting one to three partners.

EUROPE REGION

MOLDOVA

Moldova is a landlocked country in Eastern Europe, bordered by Romania to the west and Ukraine to the north, east, and south. One of the smallest countries in Europe, it has a population of approximately 2.6 million on its internationally recognized territory, with its capital at Chișinău. Recently reclassified by the World Bank as an upper-middle-income economy, Moldova nonetheless remains one of the poorest countries in Europe by per-capita income, with an economy oriented toward agriculture and food processing, services, and remittances from citizens working abroad.

Moldova's energy story is a dependency trap made suddenly, painfully visible. The country produces almost none of its own energy: it imports all of its natural gas and, historically, received the large majority of its electricity from a single gas-fired plant located in Transnistria, a breakaway region it does not control, supplied with Russian gas. When that arrangement collapsed in January 2025, the consequences were immediate: heating failures across more than a thousand apartment buildings, tens of thousands of homes without gas, schools closed for weeks, and a scramble to replace the country's primary electricity source overnight. Moldova now imports roughly 90% of its electricity from Romania at European market prices, and household tariffs have risen dramatically. Yet the country sits on an estimated 27 gigawatts of technically deployable renewable potential, overwhelmingly wind and solar, of which only a small fraction has been built. Roughly three in ten Moldovans report being unable to keep their home adequately warm, among the highest rates in Europe. The gap between what Moldova could generate and what it actually generates is the widest in the region.

KEY INDUSTRIES SHAPED BY ENERGY POVERTY

- **Agriculture and food processing.** The backbone of rural livelihoods depends on affordable electricity for irrigation, cold storage, and processing, and is squeezed hardest by tariff increases.
- **Households and the heating sector.** Aging Soviet-era housing stock, limited rural gas coverage, and reliance on firewood make winter heating the sharpest edge of Moldovan energy poverty.
- **Services and small enterprise.** Small businesses absorbing 400 to 600% energy price increases face existential cost pressure that shapes employment and emigration.

BARTERING NOTE

Eligible barter countries: Romania and Ukraine. Teams should research both eligible countries' energy resources, needs, and constraints when designing a barter arrangement.

ASIA-PACIFIC / CENTRAL ASIA REGION**UZBEKISTAN**

Uzbekistan is a doubly landlocked country in Central Asia, one of only two in the world, bordered by Kazakhstan to the north, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan to the east, Afghanistan to the south, and Turkmenistan to the west. It is Central Asia's most populous nation, with over 38 million people and its capital at Tashkent. Classified as lower-middle-income, Uzbekistan is also one of the region's fastest-growing economies, with an economic base spanning agriculture (notably cotton), gold and uranium mining, textiles, chemicals, and a rapidly expanding manufacturing and services sector.

Uzbekistan presents the most contradictory energy system in the competition set. The country sits on roughly 65 trillion cubic feet of natural gas reserves, among the largest in the world, and enjoys the highest solar irradiation in the former Soviet Union. Yet domestic gas production is in structural decline, down roughly a quarter from its 2019 peak as legacy fields deplete, and the country now consumes more gas than it produces, exporting to China under long-term contracts while importing expensive gas from Russia and Turkmenistan to cover winter shortfalls. The Soviet-era grid loses around 13% of electricity in transmission before it reaches consumers, rolling blackouts returned in the winter of 2025 to 2026, and roughly 13% of the population lacks access to safe and adequate heating. The government has set ambitious targets, including a majority-renewable power system by 2030, and solar and wind capacity is genuinely being built at pace, but fossil fuels still dominate generation and the grid needs billions in modernization to deliver new capacity reliably. Layered over all of it is the Aral Sea catastrophe in Karakalpakstan, where energy poverty, water scarcity, and ecological collapse combine into one of the hardest planning challenges on Earth.

KEY INDUSTRIES SHAPED BY ENERGY POVERTY

- **Agriculture and irrigation.** Cotton and food production depend on energy-intensive pumping and processing, nowhere more critically than in the water-stressed Aral Sea region.
- **Mining and heavy industry.** Gold, uranium, chemicals, and metallurgy require large volumes of reliable power and are directly exposed to winter supply shortfalls.
- **Manufacturing and textiles.** A fast-growing export sector whose competitiveness depends on stable, affordable electricity that the aging grid struggles to guarantee.

BARTERING NOTE

Eligible barter countries: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Afghanistan. Teams should research each eligible country's energy resources, needs, and constraints when selecting one to three partners.

AFRICA REGION**NIGERIA**

Nigeria is a West African federal republic bordered by Benin to the west, Niger to the north, Chad to the northeast, and Cameroon to the east. With a population of more than 220 million, it is Africa's most populous country and one of its largest economies, with its capital at Abuja. Classified as lower-middle-income, Nigeria's economy is supported by oil and gas, agriculture, trade, services, ICT and finance, construction, and manufacturing, though crude oil dominates export earnings and government revenue.

Nigeria is one of the world's most consequential energy poverty cases: a major hydrocarbon producer where tens of millions of people still lack electricity entirely. An estimated 87 million Nigerians were without electricity access in 2024, one of the largest access deficits on the planet, and clean cooking access remains limited for a large share of households. Even connection to the grid does not guarantee power: installed generation capacity of roughly 13,000 MW routinely delivers only a fraction of that due to gas supply shortages, transmission constraints, utility debt, and system fragility, forcing households and businesses into widespread dependence on private diesel and petrol generators. Associated gas is flared while gas-fired plants go under-supplied. The result is an energy poverty chain that runs from fuel production and gas-to-power constraints through utility performance to the household kitchen, and a planning challenge that spans grid reliability, distributed generation, clean cooking, affordability, and governance all at once.

KEY INDUSTRIES SHAPED BY ENERGY POVERTY

- **Oil and gas.** The country's largest industry and export earner, yet flaring, gas-to-power shortfalls, and infrastructure gaps mean resource wealth has not translated into household energy security.
- **Agriculture and agro-processing.** Unreliable rural power restricts irrigation, milling, refrigeration, and cold storage, driving post-harvest losses and limiting rural income.
- **Manufacturing and small business.** Outages, poor power quality, and expensive backup generation raise costs across manufacturers, SMEs, clinics, schools, and the digital economy.

BARTERING NOTE

Eligible barter countries: Benin, Cameroon, Niger, and Chad. Teams should research each eligible country's energy resources, needs, and constraints when selecting one to three partners.

AMERICAS REGION**PERU**

Peru is a South American country on the Pacific coast, bordered by Ecuador and Colombia to the north, Brazil to the east, Bolivia to the southeast, and Chile to the south. Home to roughly 34 million people with its capital at

Lima, Peru combines coastal, Andean highland, and Amazonian geographies within one national energy system. Classified as upper-middle-income, its economy is anchored by mining, above all copper, alongside natural gas, agriculture, fisheries, tourism, and services.

Peru is the competition's second-generation energy poverty case: the numbers look strong until you look closer. National electricity access is high by regional standards, yet remote Andean, Amazonian, and Indigenous communities still face genuine service gaps, weaker reliability, higher fuel logistics costs, and limited productive-use energy. Geography is the adversary: the same terrain that gives Peru world-class hydropower and mining wealth makes last-mile electrification and fuel delivery extraordinarily expensive. The system's fragility was exposed in March 2026, when a rupture of the Camisea gas pipeline disrupted nearly half of national electricity generation and most LPG distribution at a stroke, revealing how much of a seemingly advanced system hangs on a single energy corridor. A strong Peru plan must therefore solve for equity and resilience simultaneously: closing the gap between national averages and remote realities while reducing single-point-of-failure risk in the backbone of the system.

KEY INDUSTRIES SHAPED BY ENERGY POVERTY

- **Mining.** Peru is one of the world's leading copper producers; mining demands stable, high-quality, and increasingly low-carbon power, and can anchor major renewable investment.
- **Agriculture and fisheries.** Highland and Amazonian producers need power for irrigation, refrigeration, and processing, while coastal fisheries depend on cold chains and reliable fuel supply.
- **Tourism and rural enterprise.** Remote cultural and ecological tourism, and the community economies around it, depend on reliable energy for lodging, water systems, communications, and transport.

BARTERING NOTE

Eligible barter countries: Bolivia, Chile, Brazil, Ecuador, and Colombia. Teams should research each eligible country's energy resources, needs, and constraints when selecting one to three partners.

06 // THE WORKITSELF

PROMPT INSTRUCTIONS & FINANCIAL INFORMATION

Read these instructions thoroughly. Your work in the following steps is what carries you through all four rounds: the energy analysis is your Round 1 deliverable, the 10-year plan and budget are your Round 2 deliverable, and both are the substance behind your Round 3 video and Round 4 live defense. The results of the energy analysis must be included in your presentations, and all analytical content must be cited correctly and completely.

STEP 1: ASSESS THE 8 ENERGY POVERTY FACTORS

Assess the energy scenario of your chosen country across all eight factors below. All eight must be substantively addressed in your Round 1 brief.

- **1. Accessibility.** Can the country and its people access energy for cooking, electricity, transportation, and heating and cooling? How are the country's most important industries impacted by energy access or the lack of it?

- **2. Environmental Impact.** How are the country's current energy scenarios impacting the environment as a whole (land, water, atmosphere), positively or negatively?
- **3. Quality of Energy Services.** How reliable, safe, and affordable are the country's energy services at both the industrial and community levels? What is the state of demand reduction efforts such as energy efficiency programs and smart metering?
- **4. Reliability.** Are energy services provided consistently without interruption? Consider the frequency of blackouts and fuel shortages.
- **5. Affordability.** Are available energy services affordable? How much do rates vary from region to region, and are they reasonable?
- **6. Safety.** Are transmission lines and other energy infrastructure safe for consumers? Are cooking fuels impacting health? Is there adequate heating or air conditioning for extreme temperatures?
- **7. Security.** Is the country's energy infrastructure protected from attacks and disruptions? How do industries get a steady and reliable supply of energy?
- **8. Potential for Roadblocks.** Are there major challenges (political, financial, infrastructure, supply chain, employment, or transportation) that could impede progress in reducing energy poverty?

* Step 1 is your Round 1 Submission/Deliverable

STEP 2: PROPOSE A 10-YEAR PLAN

Propose a 10-year plan with solutions that will help your chosen country achieve long-term goals in relieving energy poverty.

DESIGN

- How will the country use various energy resources to improve its energy scenario? Does it need to expand or reduce existing resources, add new ones, or both?
- Focus first on developing energy resources within the country. If imports are necessary, what is required, and how can the country become more energy secure and independent over time?
- Examine the potential financial impact at the residential level, the effects on the country's key industries, and the environmental and social consequences.
- Investigate local communities and cultures. How will the government consider, engage, and communicate with those affected by the plan during design and implementation? Will local communities help shape the plan, and how?

IMPLEMENTATION

- Establish an implementation timeline over 10 years based on real-world data.
- Describe how the government will execute the plan. What public-private partnerships can share responsibilities, reduce the burden on the public sector, and drive long-term, sustainable impact?
- Each country has a maximum budget (see the Financial Information table below). List the projected costs of your proposed solutions, considering initial investment, ongoing maintenance, and the maximum budget. If projected costs exceed the limit, how will the country supplement funding?
- Describe the metrics you will use to measure the success or failure of your plan.

IMPACT

- **Environmental:** indicate how the environment as a whole (land, water, atmosphere) is impacted by your proposed solutions, both positively and negatively.
- **Social:** describe how society might respond to the proposed solutions and what cultural and quality-of-life changes communities will undergo, including education, healthcare, women's rights, food and hunger, water, transportation, and sanitation.
- **Financial:** how will the 10-year plan impact the country's GDP, trade, and overall economic development? What tangible economic benefits will your proposal offer local industries and the wider population?

STEP 3: DESIGN THE BARTER

Explore cross-border energy or resource trading with neighboring countries, based on the results of your energy analysis.

- Of all the countries sharing a border with your chosen country, which is best suited for energy or resource barter, and why? Consider no more than three neighbors.
- What key energy challenges and limitations do the neighboring countries face? How can a strategic, multi-country energy trade be designed to ensure mutual benefit?
- How will your 10-year plan support the development of new energy trade partnerships? How can such collaboration address shared energy issues and strengthen regional energy security?
- Can there be a single solution for global energy poverty?

** Steps 2 & 3 are your Round 2 Submission/Deliverable*

ADDITIONAL CONSIDERATIONS & GUIDANCE

FORWARD-LOOKING SUGGESTIONS

- Ensure proposed projects include actionable tasks and realistic goals feasible within a 10-year timeframe.
- Stay within budget limits, considering practicality, innovation, and affordability.
- Incorporate potential future technologies, keeping in mind uncertainties in their development and implementation.
- Do not overlook improvements or maintenance to existing infrastructure (modernization, upgrades, regular servicing and repairs) that extend lifespan and ensure optimal operation.
- Describe the positive impact of implementing your proposed solution.

COMMUNITY & STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT

Community engagement is the process of building relationships with the local community: communicating with them, providing opportunities to participate in processes and decisions, and becoming aware of social, environmental, and economic factors. Stakeholder engagement applies the same discipline to other entities: local and national governments, companies that would execute your plan, organizations affected by it, and potential funders. Your solution should be scientifically and economically sound and considerate of social impact, and your presentations should explain how you will address both community and stakeholder engagement. Stakeholders who understand and are aligned with your plan become advocates who help you achieve your goals and vision.

ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT & GOVERNMENT POLICIES

- Ensure your solutions include a path for economic development based on improvements in energy poverty, aligned with local priorities and the country's development goals.
- Analyze how government policies and strategies can positively influence the country's development in the energy sector.
- If the allotted 10-year budget proves insufficient, identify which borrowing institutions the government could approach for additional funding.
- Address any political issues within the country that might impact implementation of your plan.

FINANCIAL INFORMATION

Each country has been assigned a maximum budget for the 10-year plan, referred to as the Maximum Allowable Spend in Table 1. The total depends on the country's estimated energy expenditure, projected as a percentage of GDP over the next decade. Teams may propose new projects totaling up to 10% of the country's cumulative 10-year energy budget. Your Round 2 plan must state its total cost and demonstrate that it fits within this limit, or explain precisely how the country will supplement funding.

	TUNISIA	MOLDOVA	UZBEKISTAN	NIGERIA	PERU
Region	MENA / N. Africa	Europe	Asia-Pacific	Africa	Americas
GDP (USD billion, 2025)	57.6	20.3	147.1	290.794	334.855
Government expenditure (% of GDP)	33.6	36.0	29.4	12.5	21.5
% of GDP spent on energy*	3.634	4.136	7.104	2.080	2.740
Energy budget per year (USD B)	2.093	0.840	10.450	6.048	9.174
Projected avg. GDP growth, 10 yrs (%)	2.1	2.5	6.5	3.5	3.0
Cumulative energy budget, 10 yrs (USD B)	23.026	9.407	141.022	70.950	105.171
MAXIMUM ALLOWABLE SPEND (USD BILLION)	2.303	0.941	14.102	7.095	10.517

Table 1. Energy budget parameters by country. All monetary values in current USD billions.

METHODOLOGY, IN FULL

Energy spending proxy. Because no single standardized official statistic exists for “percentage of GDP spent on energy,” the competition uses a consistent economy-wide proxy. World Bank / Global Economy data provides energy use per \$1,000 of GDP in kilograms of oil equivalent; this is multiplied by a 2025 average oil-equivalent price of \$0.51 per kg, then converted to a share of GDP.

Annual energy budget. $\text{GDP} \times (\% \text{ of GDP spent on energy} \div 100)$. GDP values are 2025 current-USD figures from World Bank and IMF data.

Cumulative 10-year budget. $\text{Annual energy budget} \times \Sigma(1 + g)^n$ for $n = 0$ to 9, where g is the projected average GDP growth rate. This includes the base year plus nine growth-adjusted years.

Maximum allowable spend. 10% × cumulative 10-year energy budget. This is the ceiling for your team's proposed new projects over the plan period.

These proxy values are competition parameters: treat the Maximum Allowable Spend as a hard constraint for planning purposes. In your own research you will encounter different estimates of national energy spending; you may discuss them in your analysis, but your budget must be built against Table 1.

07 // COMPETITION STRUCTURE

THE FOUR ROUNDS

The 2026 competition is a four-round progressive tournament. Each round has a specific deliverable, a defined evaluation method, and a clear outcome, including elimination for teams that do not meet the bar. The structure builds momentum: early rounds are short, focused checkpoints; later rounds concentrate effort, mentoring, and judging where the field is strongest. All submissions flow through The Grid (Section 12).

ROUND	DELIVERABLE	DUE	EVALUATED BY	ADVANCES
1	Country selection + energy analysis brief (3—5 pages)	Sun, Sep 27	Evaluation-based screening & SEA staff review	All teams meeting baseline criteria
2	10-year plan & budget (5—8 pages)	Sun, Oct 25	Volunteer judges, 6-dimension rubric	Top ~25 teams
3	Semifinal video (12 min) + PDF supplemental	Sun, Nov 15	Judge panel, full 20-item rubric	Top 5 teams
4	Live finals: 10-min pitch + 10-min Q&A	Sat, Dec 5	Distinguished judge panel, live	Winners announced

ROUND 1 OF 4

COUNTRY SELECTION + ENERGY ANALYSIS BRIEF

DELIVERABLE	One combined submission: your chosen country, plus a written brief of 3 to 5 pages addressing all 8 energy poverty factors and identifying at least one potential bartering partner with rationale.
DEADLINE	Sunday, September 27, 2026, 11:59 PM US Central (04:59 UTC, Monday, September 28)
SUBMIT VIA	Round 1 Submission portal, inside the 2026 Switch Competition Hub on The Grid
EVALUATION	Evaluation-based screening against five baseline criteria, with SEA staff review
RESULTS	Thursday, October 1, delivered to every team through The Grid. All Round 1 decisions are final.

Round 1 is your first engagement checkpoint, and it is deliberately different from every other round: it is not a competitive ranking. Every submission is screened against the same five baseline criteria, and every team that meets them advances to Round 2. The purpose is simple: to confirm that your team has genuinely engaged with your chosen country's energy landscape before the more intensive competitive rounds begin. Country selection and the analysis brief are one combined submission, so committing to a country means committing to substantive analytical work from the start. The official country selection takes place in the submission form.

You have 13 days from the case packet release to the deadline. The Energy Analysis session of the Integrated Learning Series on September 21 lands midway through that window, giving you a full week of research before and six days after it to finalize your brief. The five criteria you will be screened against, and a note on AI use, appear in full in Section 8.

WHY THIS ROUND EXISTS

Teams that pass Round 1 enter Round 2 knowing their foundation is real, and every team in the competitive field has earned its place. If your team is eliminated here, you will receive specific feedback identifying the gaps, early enough that the work still has value for your portfolio and next year's competition.

ROUND 2 OF 4

10-YEAR PLAN & BUDGET

DELIVERABLE	Written plan of 5 to 8 pages: your 10-year energy plan, proposed energy mix, implementation timeline, budget allocation within the maximum allowable spend, success metrics, impact assessment, and detailed bartering partnership design.
DEADLINE	Sunday, October 25, 2026, 11:59 PM US Central (04:59 UTC, Monday, October 26)
SUBMIT VIA	Round 2 Submission portal, inside the Round 2 group on The Grid
EVALUATION	Volunteer judges score each plan on a 6-dimension, 100-point rubric; at least two judges per team submission
RESULTS	Semifinalists announced Thursday, November 5. The top ~25 teams advance; all others are eliminated.

Round 2 is where the intensive competitive rounds begin, the round where the quality of analytical thinking, plan design, and strategic creativity separates the field. Judges evaluate a written document rather than a video, which keeps their attention on substance, and every team receives dimension-by-dimension feedback with its results.

You have 22 days from Round 1 results to the deadline, deliberately the longest working window of any round, because the 10-year plan is the most complex and analytically demanding deliverable in the competition. The Energy Economics session (October 5) and the Planning, Budgeting & Data workshop (October 8 or 12, final date confirmed on The Grid) are positioned early in the window to give you practical tools before drafting begins: real-world cost benchmarks, budget construction, and implementation timelines grounded in reality rather than wishful thinking.

THE VIDEO DECISION POINT

Round 2 is where the competition decides which teams move on to video. Teams that advance know their analytical foundation is competitive before committing the significant effort a polished video requires. Teams that do not advance have still completed a full energy analysis and 10-year plan with genuine educational and portfolio value.

ROUND 3 OF 4

SEMIFINAL VIDEO PRESENTATIONS

DELIVERABLE	A video presentation of 12 minutes maximum, with a complementary supplemental document in PDF format, building on your Round 1 and Round 2 work, plus a current transcript or class schedule for each team member (see Section 16, Eligibility Verification).
DEADLINE	Sunday, November 15, 2026, 11:59 PM US Central (05:59 UTC, Monday, November 16)
SUBMIT VIA	Round 3 Submission portal, inside the Round 3 group on The Grid
EVALUATION	Full 20-item rubric (100 points) applied by a panel of experienced judges
RESULTS	Finalists announced Wednesday, November 25. The top 5 teams advance to the Live Finals.

Every team in the semifinal pool has survived the major competitive cut; your analytical foundation is proven. Round 3 tests something different: can you turn that analysis into a presentation that persuades? You are not conducting new research. You are translating existing work into a narrative, which is a different and faster kind of task, and the From Data to Narrative session on November 7 provides immediate coaching for exactly this transition.

The full 20-item rubric evaluates analytical substance, plan quality, narrative craft, and delivery in equal measure. Note that a quarter of the available points reward story and creativity: judges are explicitly instructed that a team filming on a phone with a clear story and a memorable through-line should outscore a polished but generic narrated slide deck. The 12-minute limit is firm, and conciseness is itself a skill this competition rewards.

What the supplemental document is. Your video carries the narrative: the problem, your plan, and why it works. The supplemental document carries the evidence behind it. Judges watch the video first, then open the document to check the full energy mix, the budget line by line, the bartering terms, your sources, and anything the twelve minutes couldn't hold. It is a reference, not a script. Structure it however serves your plan best: a technical appendix, an annotated data book, a full written plan, a set of one-page briefs on each rubric area. What matters is that every claim in the video can be found and verified in the document, and that a judge can locate any rubric item without hunting.

A note on format. The document can be anything that does this job well, including a set of slides if that's how your team thinks. What it shouldn't be is a copy of the video. If the document only repeats what's on screen, and the video only reads what's in the document, judges see the same material twice and the rubric rewards neither. The teams that score best treat them as two different tools: one to persuade, one to prove.

Keep it tight. The document is 6 to 10 pages total, and that count includes every chart, table, map, slide, and graphic. Judges are reviewing roughly 25 teams with the full rubric, so a document that says more in eight pages beats one that says the same in twenty.

ROUND 4 OF 4

LIVE FINALS

FORMAT	A 10-minute live presentation of your key findings and plan, followed by a 10-minute Q&A with a panel of distinguished judges. Broadcast live on Zoom to a global audience.
DATE	Saturday, December 5, 2026, 9:00 AM to 12:00 PM US Central (15:00 to 18:00 UTC)
EVALUATION	Judges score six dimensions (100 points) immediately after each team's Q&A; all judges' scores are totaled for final placement
OUTCOME	All fifteen prize places are announced live at the end of the event. The \$50,000 prize pool is distributed per Section 9.

The live finals are the capstone of the competition. The finals judges see your team fresh: they have not reviewed your written plans or semifinal video, by design, because this round tests whether you can earn conviction from an expert audience in twenty minutes with nothing assumed. The Q&A carries as much weight as the presentation itself: judges will probe assumptions, challenge methodology, and test whether your team truly understands its proposal or is reciting rehearsed content. Anticipating questions is a key skill and demonstrates significant preparation.

Teams present their slides live during the event. Winners are announced at the end, and after the finals SEA contacts prize-winning team leaders to distribute prize money.

THE ELIMINATION FUNNEL

Three decision points progressively narrow the field, concentrating mentor time, judge attention, and organizational support on the teams still competing.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	TEAMS IN	ADVANCE
Registration	Teams register on The Grid (Aug 17 — Sep 11)	All registered	All
Round 1 cut	Baseline screening of energy analysis briefs	All registered	Teams meeting all criteria
Round 2 cut	Judges score written 10-year plans	Round 1 qualifiers	Top ~25
Round 3 cut	Judges score semifinal videos	~25	Top 5
Round 4	Live finals	5	Winners

Elimination is a feature of the design, not a punishment. Round 1 removes only submissions that fail baseline criteria. Round 2 is the major competitive cut, based on the quality of the written plan. Round 3 refines roughly 25 teams to the final 5. At every stage, eliminated teams receive feedback and keep full access to the Competition Hub, the Integrated Learning Series recordings, and the community through the finals broadcast, which everyone is invited to watch live.

08 // FULL TRANSPARENCY

HOW EVERY ROUND IS SCORED

We publish the complete evaluation criteria for every round, up front, because we want you to aim at the real target. Judges receive the same rubrics printed here, with scoring instructions and calibration anchors. Nothing about how you will be evaluated is a secret.

ROUND 1: FIVE BASELINE CRITERIA (PASS / ADVANCE)

Round 1 uses baseline screening to evaluate submissions against specific, binary criteria. This screening does not rank teams. It checks for thoroughness, completeness and minimum genuine effort: a triage function, not a ranking function. Edge cases flagged by the screening are reviewed multiple times by SEA staff before any team is eliminated.

- **Completeness.** All 8 energy poverty factors are substantively addressed. Briefs that skip or gloss over multiple factors will not advance.
- **Source quality.** Claims are supported by credible, identifiable sources such as the IEA, World Bank, IRENA, national statistics agencies, or peer-reviewed research. Briefs with no citations will not advance.
- **Country specificity.** The analysis reflects your chosen country's actual energy landscape, with country-specific data and context. Generic content that could describe any nation will not advance.
- **Bartering identification.** At least one potential bartering partner country is identified, with a stated rationale for why the partnership makes sense.
- **Length and effort.** The brief meets the 3-page minimum and demonstrates genuine engagement with the material.

A NOTE ON AI USE

We encourage you to use AI tools for research, learning, and understanding your country's energy landscape. They are excellent for finding data sources, explaining concepts, and pressure-testing your thinking. However, the analysis and writing in your submissions must be your own. Your conclusions, your reasoning, and your words are what this competition develops and what we evaluate. Work that reads as AI-generated rather than team-authored undermines the purpose of the exercise and reflects poorly in evaluation, since AI-written content tends to be generic rather than country-specific.

WHAT STRONG BRIEFS DO

- Anchor every factor in current, country-specific data, and name the source. A brief built on 2015 statistics reads very differently from one built on the latest IEA country profile.
- Treat the 8 factors as a connected system, not a checklist. The strongest briefs show how affordability pressures reliability, or how security concerns shape accessibility.
- Choose a bartering partner for a reason. One well-reasoned partner with a clear mutual benefit beats a list of neighbors with no rationale.

- Stay inside 5 pages. Concision is a skill this competition rewards at every round.

ROUND 2: SIX DIMENSIONS, 100 POINTS

At least two judges score every plan independently, giving one score per dimension plus a brief written comment and feedback. Judges are instructed to score the plan on the page and to reserve top scores for work that would hold up in front of an energy investment committee.

DIMENSION	PTS	WHAT JUDGES ASSESS
Energy Analysis Quality	25	Depth and accuracy across the 8 factors; source quality and currency; country-specific insight versus generic treatment.
Plan Design & Innovation	25	Energy mix rationale; technology choices; infrastructure strategy; stakeholder engagement; creativity of approach.
Implementation & Budget	20	Timeline realism based on real-world data; budget discipline within the maximum allowable spend; success metrics; government execution pathway.
Bartering Strategy	15	Partner selection reasoning; mutual benefit demonstration; political, technical, and logistical feasibility.
Impact Assessment	10	Environmental, social, and financial consequences; community and cultural sensitivity; public health considerations.
Writing & Sources	5	Clarity of argument; organization; proper citation of credible sources.

ROUND 3: THE FULL 20-ITEM RUBRIC, 100 POINTS

Each of the 20 items is scored 0 to 5. Blocks A and B are largely confirmed against your PDF supplemental document; Blocks C and D are judged from the video itself. Items 11 through 15 map directly to the From Data to Narrative session, so teams that engage with the coaching should visibly benefit.

BLOCK A. ANALYTICAL FOUNDATION (25 PTS)

- 1. Analytical depth: depth and accuracy of the 8-factor energy analysis.
- 2. Data currency and credibility: recent data; credible, cited sources.
- 3. Country-specific insight: analysis clearly rooted in the chosen country.
- 4. Problem framing: the challenge is framed clearly and precisely.
- 5. Assumptions and methodology: assumptions stated; methods transparent.

BLOCK B. PLAN QUALITY (25 PTS)

- 6. Energy mix rationale: technology and mix choices argued, not asserted.
- 7. Timeline realism: implementation grounded in real-world benchmarks.
- 8. Budget discipline: sound allocation logic within the maximum allowable spend.
- 9. Success metrics: measurable progress with a credible measurement approach.
- 10. Bartering feasibility: partnership plausible and mutually beneficial.

BLOCK C. NARRATIVE & CREATIVITY (25 PTS)

- 11. Story arc: the video builds toward a conclusion rather than reciting sections.

- **12.** The “why this matters” thread: human stakes present throughout, not just data.
- **13.** Data storytelling: numbers framed as evidence, with context that makes them land.
- **14.** Format creativity: choices that go beyond a narrated slide deck.
- **15.** Memorability: a hook, through-line, or moment that distinguishes the video.

BLOCK D. DELIVERY & PROFESSIONALISM (25 PTS)

- **16.** Speaking clarity and confidence: clear, confident, easy to follow.
- **17.** Team coordination: balanced participation and smooth transitions.
- **18.** Pacing and time discipline: the 12-minute limit used well; no rushing, no padding.
- **19.** Risks and mitigation: risks acknowledged and management addressed.
- **20.** Citation and attribution: sources properly credited in video and slides.

CREATIVITY IS NOT A PRODUCTION BUDGET

Block C rewards narrative craft and creative choices, not expensive equipment. Judges are instructed to score the choices, not the camera. A team filming on a phone, with a clear story and a memorable through-line, should outscore a polished but generic narrated slide deck.

ROUND 4: LIVE FINALS SCORING, 100 POINTS

Finals judges score six dimensions immediately after each team's Q&A ends, before the next team begins. They see your team fresh, with no prior review of your written plans or video, and they are instructed to score each team against the rubric rather than against each other. All judges' scores are totaled for final placement.

DIMENSION	PTS	WHAT JUDGES ASSESS
Analysis & Understanding	20	Does the team demonstrate deep, country-specific command of the energy poverty challenge?
Plan Quality & Feasibility	25	Is the 10-year plan creative, realistic, budget-disciplined, and defensible?
Bartering & Impact	15	Is the partnership strategy plausible and mutually beneficial? Are consequences and tradeoffs addressed honestly?
Presentation Effectiveness	15	Clear narrative, strong visuals, command of the material, and timing discipline within the 10-minute limit.
Q&A Performance	20	Directness of answers, depth of understanding beyond rehearsed content, and composure under challenge.
Overall Impression	5	The judges' holistic read: would they fund this team?

POTENTIAL DEDUCTIONS (ALL ROUNDS)

- Late submission: 10 points (Rounds 2 and 3). Submissions received more than 12 hours after a deadline will be disqualified. Round 1 submissions must arrive by the deadline to be screened.
- Failure to follow submission requirements in Section 15: 1 point per item.
- Round 3 videos with any team member not shown and audible as required: per-item deductions apply.

09 // \$50,000 PRIZE POOL

PRIZES

The 2026 competition awards a total prize pool of \$50,000 USD across the top fifteen teams, double the deepest prize structure in competition history. Places 1 through 5 are determined at the Live Finals on December 5 and announced live. Places 6 through 15 are determined by Round 3 semifinal scores and are also announced live at the finals, so all fifteen prize places are revealed on December 5. All amounts are per team, to be divided evenly among team members.

PLACE	PRIZE (USD)	DETERMINED BY
1st Place	\$12,500	Live Finals, December 5
2nd Place	\$10,000	Live Finals, December 5
3rd Place	\$7,000	Live Finals, December 5
4th Place	\$5,000	Live Finals, December 5
5th Place	\$3,000	Live Finals, December 5
6th — 10th Place	\$1,500 each	Round 3 semifinal scores
11th — 15th Place	\$1,000 each	Round 3 semifinal scores

The top five finalist teams will be featured on SEA's website, newsletter, and social media. After the finals, SEA will contact team leaders of all prize-winning teams to distribute prize money. Finalists will also be contacted with information about internship opportunities set aside for Switch Competition finalists; details will be announced during the competition.

10 // LEARN IT WHEN YOU NEED IT

THE INTEGRATED LEARNING SERIES

The Integrated Learning Series is the educational backbone of the competition. Rather than optional, loosely scheduled webinars, each session is timed to directly support the work your team needs to do in the upcoming round: research skills before Round 1, planning and budgeting before Round 2, and narrative craft before Round 3. The skills taught map directly to what you will be evaluated on next.

LIVE + ON-DEMAND, FOR EVERY TIME ZONE

Because the competition draws teams from many different countries, every session is offered live and simultaneously recorded. Recordings are posted to the Competition Hub on The Grid within 24 hours. Live attendance is encouraged but never mandatory; engage with the content on whatever schedule your time

zone allows. Recordings of the pre-competition Interest and Info Sessions are already available in the Hub library.

SESSION 1. THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 17**DECISION MAKING, WITH DR. STEVE BEGG**

Every round of this competition is, at its core, a series of decisions made under uncertainty: which country, which energy mix, which partner, which tradeoffs. This opening session with Dr. Steve Begg, a leading expert on decision-making, covers how good decisions differ from good outcomes, the biases that quietly distort judgment, how to frame a decision before debating it, and how to reason with uncertain information instead of pretending it is certain. The habits taught here compound through every deliverable that follows.

ALL TEAMS · SUPPORTS EVERY ROUND

SESSION 2. MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 21**HOW TO CONDUCT AN ENERGY ANALYSIS, WITH DR. MOONES ALAMOOTI**

Leading this session is Dr. Moones Alamooti, Assistant Professor at the University of North Dakota, whose work sits at the intersection of subsurface geoscience and energy systems engineering. Her research spans petroleum petrophysics and enhanced oil recovery in the Bakken, geothermal resource characterization and the conversion of depleted wells to thermal storage, battery and hybrid storage systems, and grid reliability. Few people are as well placed to show a team how to move from raw country data to an analysis that holds up.

ALL TEAMS · SUPPORTS
ROUND 1

SESSION 3. MONDAY, OCTOBER 5**ENERGY ECONOMICS, WITH DR. KENNETH MEDLOCK**

The jump from “here is what’s wrong” to “here is what we’d do about it, with numbers” is where teams historically struggle. This expert session covers energy economics fundamentals, supply chain considerations, how energy investment decisions are made in practice, and how government energy budgets actually work.

Leading this session is Dr. Kenneth B. Medlock III, one of the world’s foremost energy economists: the James A. Baker, III, and Susan G. Baker Fellow in Energy and Resource Economics at Rice University’s Baker Institute, Senior Director of its Center for Energy Studies, and a scholar whose expertise on energy markets, supply chains, and economic development has been sought everywhere from Capitol Hill to OPEC.

ROUND 2 TEAMS · SUPPORTS ROUND 2

SESSION 4. OCTOBER 8 OR 12 (FINAL DATE CONFIRMED ON THE GRID)**PLANNING, BUDGETING & FINDING THE DATA**

A practical workshop companion to Session 2: where to find cost benchmarks (IRENA, Lazard LCOE, World Bank project databases), how to build a 10-year budget, working within your country’s maximum allowable spend, structuring an implementation timeline grounded in reality, and how to measure success.

ROUND 2 TEAMS · SUPPORTS ROUND 2

SESSION 5. SATURDAY, NOVEMBER 7

FROM DATA TO NARRATIVE: A FIRESIDE CHAT

Strong analysis does not automatically make a persuasive presentation, so we asked three leaders who have spent their careers persuading boards, investors, and communities to talk about how it is really done. Moderated by Chinaza Arukwe, Lead Administrator of the Switch Ambassador Network (University of Miskolc, Hungary), this fireside chat brings together an all-star group:

- Dr. Scott Tinker, Founder and Board Chair of Switch Energy Alliance
- Mike Howard, CEO of Howard Energy Partners
- Deborah Byers, long-time industry professional and retired Partner at Ernst & Young

The conversation is about the craft at the heart of Round 3: turning your data into a narrative story, so the numbers stop sitting on slides and start persuading. The guests share how they bring figures to life for boards, investors, and communities, and what separates a story that moves decision-makers from a recitation of findings. Released two days after semifinalists are announced, and Round 3 rubric items 11 through 15 map directly to its themes.

SEMIFINALISTS · SUPPORTS ROUND 3

THE LEARNING ARC

Energy Analysis (how do I research?) → Energy Economics + Planning Workshop (how do I build a plan?) → From Data to Narrative (how do I tell this story?). Each session directly prepares you for the next deliverable. You don't just learn: you learn at the moment you need it most.

11 // EVERY DATE THAT MATTERS

2026 MASTER TIMELINE

All deadlines are 11:59 PM US Central Time on the date shown unless otherwise noted. In UTC that is 04:59 the following day through October (Rounds 1 and 2) and 05:59 the following day from November onward (Round 3), because US clocks change on November 1.. The Competition Hub on The Grid is the authoritative source for any updates.

DATE	MILESTONE	DETAILS
Aug 17 – Sep 11	Registration window	Teams registered through The Grid. Registration is now closed.
Mon, Sep 14	COMPETITION BEGINS	Case packet released in the 2026 Switch Competition Hub; mentor pairing begins. Teams that requested a mentor are notified no later than Friday, September 18.
Tue, Sep 15	Kickoff event	9:00 AM Central (14:00 UTC). A walkthrough of the case packet, what to know for Round 1, and live Q&A. Recorded and posted to the Hub.
Mon, Sep 21	LEARNING SERIES 1	How to Conduct an Energy Analysis.

DATE	MILESTONE	DETAILS
Sun, Sep 27	ROUND 1 DUE	Country selection + energy analysis brief (3–5 pages), 11:59 PM US Central (04:59 UTC, Monday, September 28)
Sep 28 – 30	Round 1 evaluation	Screened against the Round 1 criteria; reviewed by SEA staff
Thu, Oct 1	ROUND 1 RESULTS	Advancement or elimination delivered with feedback via The Grid. All decisions are final.
Mon, Oct 5	LEARNING SERIES 2	Energy Economics & Supply Chains.
Oct 8 or 12	LEARNING SERIES 3	Planning, Budgeting & Finding the Data workshop.
Sun, Oct 25	ROUND 2 DUE	11:59 PM US Central (04:59 UTC, Monday, October 26)
Oct 26 – 28	SEA staff review	Submissions reviewed and assigned to judges.
Oct 28 – Nov 4	Round 2 judging	Judges score written plans on the 6-dimension rubric.
Thu, Nov 5	SEMIFINALISTS ANNOUNCED	Top ~25 teams advance; teams moved into the Round 3 group on The Grid.
Sat, Nov 7	LEARNING SERIES 4	From Data to Narrative: fireside chat for semifinalists.
Sun, Nov 15	ROUND 3 DUE	Semifinal video (12 min) + PDF supplemental document, 11:59 PM US Central (05:59 UTC, Monday, November 16)
Nov 17 – 23	Semifinal judging	Full 20-item rubric applied; judges pre-assigned at the semifinal announcement.
Wed, Nov 25	FINALISTS ANNOUNCED	Top 5 teams advance; teams moved into the Round 4 group on The Grid.
Sat, Dec 5	ROUND 4: LIVE FINALS	10-minute live presentations + 10-minute Q&A, 9:00 AM to 12:00 PM US Central (15:00 to 18:00 UTC) on Zoom. All fifteen prize places announced live.

Dark rows: competition deadlines and decision points. Shaded rows: Integrated Learning Series sessions.

12 // THE COMPETITION PLATFORM

YOUR GUIDE TO THE GRID

The entire 2026 competition runs on The Grid, Switch Energy Alliance's digital community platform at switchedu.org. Every submission, announcement, resource, learning session, and result flows through it: no scattered Google Forms, no lost email chains. Set yourself up correctly in the first week and the rest of the competition runs smoothly.

GETTING SET UP: FIVE STEPS

- 1. Activate your account.** Every registered team member receives an invitation to The Grid at the email address provided during registration. Accept it, create your profile, and add your university and discipline. If any teammate has not received an invitation, the team leader should contact us immediately (Section 17).
- 2. Join the 2026 Switch Competition Hub.** The Hub is the central home of the competition, where all announcements, updates, and resources are located. Registered participants are added automatically; confirm you can see the Hub in your groups list. If you cannot, contact us before the September 27 deadline, not after.

3. **Learn where things live.** Inside the Hub: the announcements feed (official communications, results notices), the resource library (this case packet, learning session recordings, templates), the events calendar (register for each live Integrated Learning Series session), the community discussion space (ask questions, meet other teams), and the Round 1 Submission portal.
4. **Turn on notifications.** Enable email notifications for the Hub in your Grid account settings so announcements and results reach your inbox. Add switchedu.org and switchon.org addresses to your approved sender list so nothing lands in spam.
5. **Meet your team there.** Use The Grid as your team's connection point to the competition community: the discussion space is monitored by SEA staff, and questions asked there benefit every team.

SUBMISSIONS & ROUND GROUPS

Round 1. Submit through the Round 1 Submission portal inside the 2026 Switch Competition Hub. The portal validates your file type before accepting the upload, and your team leader receives a confirmation (please ensure the Team Leader is the one submitting all submissions). If you do not receive a confirmation, your submission did not go through.

Rounds 2 through 4. Advancing teams are moved into round-specific groups on The Grid: Round 2, Round 3, and Round 4. Each round group contains that round's submission portal, round-specific resources and materials, and results communications. Access to each group is itself your confirmation of advancement: when the Round 2 group appears in your groups list on October 1, you're in.

Results. Every team receives its results and feedback through The Grid and Team Leader's email on the dates in the master timeline: October 1 (Round 1), November 5 (semifinalists), and November 25 (finalists). Results are also announced in the Hub feed.

SUBMISSION DISCIPLINE

Do not wait until 11:55 PM. Portals close at the deadline exactly, and upload time for video files in particular can run long on slower connections. Aim to submit at least a few hours early, confirm you receive a confirmation email that ensures submission, and keep your source files. Technical issues reported before a deadline can be helped; those reported after cannot.

13 // YOUR SOUNDING BOARD

THE MENTORSHIP PROGRAM

Teams that requested a mentor during registration are paired with one of the energy professionals and academics who volunteer their time to help you succeed. Mentor pairing begins September 14, and every team that requested a mentor is notified through The Grid no later than Friday, September 18. A mentor may support up to two teams. These volunteers span the full energy spectrum: upstream, midstream, downstream, power, renewables, infrastructure, finance, analytics, and academia.

HOW MENTORING WORKS

- **The team leader initiates.** It is the team leader's responsibility to contact the assigned mentor and arrange 30-minute weekly mentoring sessions, accommodating the mentor's time zone and work schedule. Agree on a video platform that works for both sides.
- **Mentors guide; teams produce.** Mentors act as a sounding board, keep teams on track, help develop team roles, assist with goal-setting, and encourage critical, interdisciplinary thinking. Mentors shall not recommend specific solutions to the prompt, engage in research, create materials, or draft language. All work must be your own (Section 16).
- **Mentoring follows the rounds.** Good teams use their mentor differently at each stage: pressure-testing source quality before Round 1, sanity-checking budget assumptions and timeline realism before Round 2, and serving as a practice audience before Rounds 3 and 4.
- **Be respectful of their time.** Mentors are professionals volunteering their time. Come to each session with an agenda, and be courteous in all communications.
- **Communication is a commitment.** Mentors can report missed meetings, unanswered messages, and last-minute cancellations to the Switch Competition team. A team that fails to communicate reliably and professionally can lose its mentor for the remainder of the competition, with no replacement.

14 // WHO EVALUATES YOUR WORK

JUDGING

Energy professionals from numerous fields, countries, and organizations judge team submissions in Rounds 2, 3, and 4. No travel is necessary; this is a virtual competition, and all judging flows through The Grid. Judge recruitment deliberately reflects the diversity of the energy industry itself: professional backgrounds across every fuel and technology, and rubrics that weight real energy poverty impact.

FAIRNESS PROTECTIONS

- At least two judges score every Round 2 plan independently.
- Round 3 semifinal videos are evaluated by an experienced panel using the full 20-item rubric, with judges pre-assigned so every video gets an unhurried review.
- Judges score the Round 3 video and the supplemental document together, as one submission. Each should do what the other can't, and the strongest teams decide for themselves how to split that work.
- Finals judges see finalist teams fresh, with no prior review of earlier-round materials, and score each team against the rubric rather than against each other.
- Judges support their scoring with constructive comments, which are returned to teams as feedback.

15 // FORMATS & SPECIFICATIONS

SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

YOUR TEAM NUMBER

Every team receives a three-digit team number during the first week of the competition, sent by email to the Team Leader. It is how the Switch team tracks your work from Round 1 through the finals, and it goes on every submission you make. Commit it to memory and write it down where the whole team can find it.

WRITTEN ROUNDS: 1 & 2

- **Format.** PDF only. Compose in any tool (Word, Google Docs, LaTeX) and export to PDF before submitting.
- **Length.** Round 1: 3 to 5 pages. Round 2: 5 to 8 pages. Your bibliography does not count toward the page limit; everything else does. Judges will not consider content beyond the limit.
- **Layout.** Letter or A4, minimum 11-point body text, reasonable margins. Figures and tables are welcome and count toward the page limit.
- **Citations.** Every claim drawn from a source must be cited, and a complete bibliography must close the document. Any consistent citation style is acceptable.
- **Title block.** The first page must state your team number, team name, university or universities, chosen country, and (Round 2) your bartering partner countries.
- **File naming.** Round 1: “[3-digit team #]_[TeamName]_R1_2026.pdf” (example: 001_SEA_R1_2026.pdf). Round 2: same convention with R2.

ROUND 3: VIDEO + SUPPLEMENTAL DOCUMENT

Round 3 asks for two artifacts: a video presentation and a PDF supplemental document. The video is the primary tool judges use to score; the document is their reference for supporting detail, data, and sources. How you use the 12 minutes is a creative decision the rubric explicitly rewards: a quarter of the available points sit in Narrative & Creativity, and judges are instructed to value choices that go beyond a narrated slide deck. Twelve minutes is short, so be comprehensive and concise.

Video requirements

- Maximum 12 minutes. Judges are instructed to end the video at the 12-minute mark, viewed at 1x speed. Do not speed up your recording to fit more content.
- The format is yours to design. Narrated slides, documentary style, on-location footage, interviews, animation, or a hybrid are all welcome. There is no requirement that slides remain on screen, that a speaker be visible at all times, or that every team member appear on camera. Creativity is judged on your choices, not your production budget.
- Each team member must speak at least once during the video.
- Whatever the format, your analytical work must come through. Any data, figures, or research shown on screen must be legible, and external research or figures must be cited on screen or in your supplemental document.
- All footage and content must be created by your team. No externally produced video content may be embedded in your video or supplemental document.
- Quality 1920×1080p or 1280×720p; MP4 format; 3 GB maximum file size.

- File naming: “[3-digit team #]_[TeamName]_R3_2026.mp4”.

Supplemental document requirements

- **PDF supplemental document.** A single PDF, 6 to 10 pages total, including every chart, table, visual, and citation. It should let a judge verify anything in your video and find any rubric item without hunting. How you structure it is up to you. Pages beyond ten are not read.
- **First page:** team name and number, team members' names, mentor's name (if applicable), home countries of team members, chosen country, and bartering partner countries.
- **Verification documents:** a current transcript or current class schedule for each team member, combined into a single PDF and uploaded alongside your video and supplemental document. Round 3 submissions without it are incomplete.
- File naming: “[3-digit team #]_[TeamName]_R3_2026.pdf”.

ROUND 4: LIVE FINALS

- 10-minute live presentation with slides presented live on Zoom, followed by 10-minute Q&A. The Zoom invitation is sent to the team leader's email and shared with all semifinalist teams to watch.
- A stable internet connection, microphone, and camera are required; finalist teams should be comfortable with Zoom screen sharing before event day.

TECHNOLOGY & LANGUAGE

- This is a virtual competition: a stable internet connection is required throughout, and video conferencing is used for mentoring and the finals.
- English is the medium of the competition. Unless prior arrangements have been made with the Switch Competition team, all written submissions, slides, and video narration must be in English.

16 // THE FINE PRINT THAT MATTERS

RULES & MISCELLANEOUS

ORIGINAL WORK

Besides meeting with your mentor, teams are permitted to contact whomever they wish, but must produce original work solely attributable to the team members. The AI use policy in Section 8 applies to every round: AI tools are welcome for research and learning, but the analysis, reasoning, and writing you submit must be your own.

PUBLICITY DISCLOSURE AGREEMENT

By participating in the competition, each team member consents that their name, photo, university affiliation, major or discipline, and presentations may be posted in SEA's newsletters, website, and social media, with similar materials shared with third parties that might deem the presentations beneficial, including government officials,

thought leaders, and organizations. If a team member does not wish to have their name or photo shared publicly, they may contact SEA via email by October 1st to discuss options.

TEAM ELIGIBILITY

Teams are three or four members. At least two members must be undergraduates; graduate students are welcome but cannot make up the majority. Every member must be currently enrolled in a degree program for the duration of the competition, and a person may compete on only one team. Teams that do not meet these requirements are not eligible to advance, regardless of the quality of their work.

TEAM CHANGES & ROSTER LOCK

Rosters can change until the Round 1 deadline. To add, replace, or remove a member, change your Team Leader, correct a name or email, or rename your team, the Team Leader submits the [Team Change Request Form](#). Only the Team Leader files it, and you will receive a confirmation when the change is recorded. Changes sent by email or posted on The Grid are not applied until the form is in. Rosters lock at 11:59 PM US Central on Sunday, September 27 (04:59 UTC, Monday, September 28), and the roster on file at that moment is the one that competes.

ELIGIBILITY VERIFICATION (ROUND 3)

New in 2026, every team that advances to Round 3 submits a current transcript or a current class schedule for each team member, as a single PDF, alongside the Round 3 video and slides. Either document is acceptable so long as it shows the member's name, institution, and current enrollment. This is not a response to a past problem; the competition has never had a known eligibility issue. It exists because the work you produce here goes into your portfolio, in front of industry professionals, and into the story you tell in interviews, and that only holds if everyone knows the field was honest. If you are eligible, it takes a few minutes in November.

DEADLINES ARE DEADLINES

All Round 1 decisions are final; there is no resubmission or remediation window in 2026, so build in buffer time and submit early. For Rounds 2 and 3, late submissions incur a 10-point deduction, and submissions received 12 or more hours past the deadline are disqualified.

DEADLINES AT A GLANCE

SUBMISSION	WHERE	DEADLINE
Round 1: Country + Energy Analysis Brief (PDF)	Round 1 portal • Competition Hub	Sun, Sep 27, 11:59 PM US Central (04:59 UTC Mon, Sep 28)
Round 2: 10-Year Plan & Budget (PDF)	Round 2 group portal	Sun, Oct 25, 11:59 PM US Central (04:59 UTC Mon, Oct 26)
Round 3: Video (MP4) + Supplemental Document (PDF)	Round 3 group portal	Sun, Nov 15, 11:59 PM US Central (05:59 UTC Mon, Nov 16)
Round 4: Live presentation	Live on Zoom	Sat, Dec 5, 9:00 AM US Central (15:00 UTC)

17 // WE'RE HERE TO HELP

CONTACT & THE COMPETITION TEAM

For questions at any point during the competition, post in the Competition Hub discussion space on The Grid, where answers benefit every team. It's important to be able to have questions answered efficiently and be transparent with all teams. If you have a question or issue that is personal in nature and should not be discussed openly or if you are not comfortable with asking the question, feel free to reach out to our team directly at the contact below:

PRIMARY CONTACT

Zach Carr

Higher Education Program Manager | Switch Energy Alliance

Email: zach.carr@switchon.org

Phone: (601) 916-6376

Web: switchedu.org

Add switchon.org and switchedu.org addresses to your approved sender list so important emails are never sent to junk or spam folders.

THE 2026 SWITCH COMPETITION TEAM

Gary Hines — President, Switch Energy Alliance

Zach Carr — Higher Education Program Manager

Carl Steffensen — Program Advisor

Abiy Kifle Assefa — Competition Intern

Teymur Ismayilov — Competition Intern

Thank you for joining the 2026 Switch Global Case Competition.

We look forward to the solutions your team conceives.